EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 1

The Final Word

Hebrews 1:1–14

TO GET STARTED

When you receive important news, how do you most want to hear it – by text message, as a rumour, or from the person themselves? Why?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Hebrews names no author and opens without a greeting. It reads like a sermon to a congregation of Jewish Christians (perhaps in or near Rome, cf. 13:24) who are under heavy pressure and tempted to go back to the visible temple service, the priesthood and the law of Moses. Tonight we read chapter 1: God's final word in the Son (vv. 1–4), and a string of seven Old Testament quotations showing that the Son is far above the angels (vv. 5–14).

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 1:1–2

[1] In many parts and in many ways God spoke in the past to the fathers through the
prophets; [2] at the end of these days he has spoken to us through the Son. Him he
appointed heir of everything, and through him he also made the worlds.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 1:3–5

3 He is the radiance of his glory and the very stamp of his being, and he carries all
things by the powerful word. When he himself had made purification for sins, he
took his seat at the right hand of the Majesty on high, 4 and so he has become as
much better than the angels as the name he has inherited is superior to theirs.

5 For to which of the angels did he ever say:

You are my Son;
today I have fathered you?
And again:
I will be a father to him,
and he will be a son to me?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 1:6–8

6 And when he again brings the firstborn into the world, he says:

And let all God's angels worship him.
7 With regard to the angels he says:

He makes his angels winds,
and his ministers a flame of fire.
8 But with regard to the Son:

Your throne, O God, stands for ever and ever,
and the sceptre of uprightness is the sceptre of your kingdom.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 1:9–10

9 You have loved righteousness and hated lawlessness;
therefore God, your God, has anointed you
with the oil of rejoicing beyond your partners.
10 And:

In the beginning, Lord, you laid the foundation of the earth,
and the heavens are the works of your hands.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 1:11–12

11 They will perish, but you remain;
they will all wear out like a garment,
12 and like a cloak you will roll them up;
like a garment they will also be changed.
But you are the same,
and your years will never come to an end.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 1:13–14

13 But to which of the angels has he ever said:

Sit at my right hand
until I make your enemies
a footstool for your feet?
14 Are they not all ministering spirits, sent out to serve for the sake of those who are going to inherit salvation?

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀπαύγασμα

apaugasma · “radiance”

The radiance or shining-out of light. Just as you cannot separate the sun from its rays, Christ is the visible radiance of God's invisible glory – he does not merely reflect God's light as the moon reflects the sun, he radiates God's own glory (1:3).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

χαρακτήρ

charaktēr · "very stamp"

The source of our word character: the exact impression a signet ring makes in warm wax, or the image struck on a coin, showing every finest line of the original. Christ is the exact expression of God's being (hypostasis, 1:3).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

λειτουργικὰ πνεύματα

leitourgika pneumata · "ministering spirits"

Literally liturgical, serving spirits. No angel was ever told to sit at God's right hand (Psalm 110:1); the angels are heaven's support staff – sent out to serve those who are going to inherit salvation (1:14).

THE BIG IDEA

God has spoken his final word in his Son, who radiates his glory, carries all things, has made purification for sins and now reigns far above the angels – so we can rest in his finished work and anchor our lives in the one who remains the same.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

In Greek, verses 1–4 are a single sentence. In the past God spoke “in many parts and in many ways”; now “he has spoken to us through the Son”. What is the difference between receiving messages from God and receiving his Son as his final word?

Hebrews 1:1–2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Christ is “the radiance of his glory and the very stamp of his being”. If you want to know what God is like, where do you look – and what do you see in Jesus?

Hebrews 1:3

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“He carries all things by the powerful word.” The devotional describes this carrying as moving something forward to a destination, not balancing a dead weight like Atlas. Which part of your life feels as if it is falling apart – and what changes if he is carrying it?

Hebrews 1:3

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The tabernacle had no chair for the priests; their work was never finished. But “when he himself had made purification for sins, he took his seat”. Where are you still standing – trying to earn God's favour – instead of resting in his finished work?

Hebrews 1:3–4

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The first readers were tempted to fall back on what was visible, familiar and impressive. We may not bow before angels today – which substitutes fascinate us more than Jesus himself?

Hebrews 1:4–7

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The Father says to the Son: “Your throne, O God, stands for ever and ever.” What does it mean for us that the one who was crucified is addressed as God and reigns?

Hebrews 1:8–9

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“But you are the same, and your years will never come to an end.” Bodies grow old, relationships change, economies falter. Where do you need the unchanging Christ this week? And how does verse 14 comfort you – angels “sent out to serve for the sake of those who are going to inherit salvation”?

Hebrews 1:10–14

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week, before you look at the news or your phone, read Hebrews 1:3 and name one burden you are handing over to the one who carries all things.
- Name one area where you still try to do enough for God before you dare to come to him. Thank him in so many words that the purification is finished and that he has sat down.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verses 1–3 aloud together, slowly. Then pray in pairs: worship the Son for who he is (the radiance of God's glory, the very stamp of his being, the one who carries all things, the King), name one thing that feels out of control, and give it to him. Close by thanking God that his angels serve those who are going to inherit salvation.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 10

The New and Living Way

Hebrews 10:1–39

TO GET STARTED

Think of something you had to repeat again and again – a medicine, a repair, a chore. How do you know when a problem has been fixed for good?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 10 brings the great teaching on Christ as high priest to its closing chord: the yearly sacrifices only reminded people of their sins, but Christ's one offering has done what they never could (10:1–18). Then, at 10:19, the letter turns from what Christ has done to how we are to live: three times “let us”. A fourth serious warning follows (10:26–31), and then warm encouragement that leads into the great faith chapter, Hebrews 11.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:1–3

[1] For the law has only a shadow of the good things to come, not the very form of the realities. So it can never, by the same sacrifices that they offer continually year after year, make perfect those who approach. [2] Otherwise, would they not have stopped being offered? For the worshippers, once cleansed, would no longer have any sins on their conscience. [3] But in these sacrifices there is a reminder of sins year after year.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:4–6

4 For it is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins.

5 Therefore, when he comes into the world, he says:

Sacrifice and offering you did not want,
but a body you have prepared for me;
6 in burnt offerings and sin offerings
you took no pleasure.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:7–8

7 Then I said: See, I have come –
in the scroll of the book it is written of me –
to do your will, O God.
8 Above he says: "Sacrifices and offerings and burnt offerings and sin offerings you did not want, nor did you take pleasure in them" – these are offered according to the law.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:9–12

9 Then he has said: "See, I have come to do your will." He takes away the first in order
to establish the second. 10 By this will we have been made holy through the offering
of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.

11 Every priest stands day after day ministering and offering again and again the
same sacrifices, which can never take away sins. 12 But this one offered one sacrifice
for sins for all time and took his seat at the right hand of God,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:13–15

13 and from then on he waits until his enemies are made a footstool for his feet. 14 For
by one offering he has made perfect for all time those who are made holy. 15 And the
Holy Spirit also testifies to us; for after saying:

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:16–17

16 This is the covenant that I will make with them
after those days, says the Lord:
I will put my laws on their hearts,
and I will write them on their minds,
17 and their sins and their lawless deeds
I will remember no more.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:18–21

18 Where there is forgiveness of these, there is no longer any offering for sin.

19 So, brothers and sisters, since we have confidence to enter the sanctuary by the blood of Jesus, 20 by the new and living way that he inaugurated for us through the curtain, that is, his flesh, 21 and since we have a great priest over the house of God,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:22–24

22 let us approach with a true heart in full assurance of faith, with our hearts
sprinkled clean from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water.
23 Let us hold fast to the confession of hope, unwavering, for the one who made the
promise is faithful. 24 And let us consider one another, so as to spur one another on
to love and good works,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:25–27

25 not abandoning our own meeting together, as is the habit of some, but
encouraging one another, and all the more as you see the Day drawing near.

26 For if we sin deliberately after we have received the knowledge of the truth, there
no longer remains a sacrifice for sins, 27 but only a fearful expectation of judgment
and the fury of a fire that will consume the adversaries.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:28–30

28 Anyone who has set aside the law of Moses dies without pity on the testimony of
two or three witnesses. 29 How much worse punishment, do you think, will be
deserved by the one who has trampled on the Son of God, has regarded as unclean
the blood of the covenant by which he was made holy, and has insulted the Spirit of
grace? 30 For we know the one who said:

Vengeance is mine; I will repay.
And again:
The Lord will judge his people.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:31–33

31 To fall into the hands of the living God is a fearful thing.

32 But remember the earlier days, when, after you had been enlightened, you endured a hard struggle with sufferings, 33 sometimes being made a public spectacle through reproaches and afflictions, and sometimes standing in fellowship with those who were treated in this way.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:34–37

34 For you sympathized with the prisoners, and you accepted the seizure of your
possessions with joy, knowing that you yourselves have a better possession, one
that lasts. 35 So do not throw away your confidence, which has a great reward. 36 For
you need endurance, so that when you have done the will of God you may receive
the promise.

37 For yet a very little while,
and the one who is coming will come and will not delay;

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 10:38–39

38 but my righteous one will live by faith,
and if he draws back,
my soul takes no pleasure in him.
39 But we are not of those who draw back to destruction, but of those who have faith
to the preserving of the soul.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

τετελείωκεν … τοὺς ἁγιαζομένους

teteleiōken … tous hagiazomenous · “he has made perfect … those who are made holy”

Two tenses side by side in 10:14: a perfect tense – our standing before God is already settled – and a present participle – we are being made holy day by day. Already perfect in God's eyes, and still growing.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

πρόσφατος

prosphatos · "new"

Originally fresh, recently made. The way Jesus inaugurated through the curtain (10:20) always stays fresh: his sacrifice is as powerful before God today as on the day of the cross – and because he is risen, it is a living way.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

παρρησία

parrēsia · "confidence"

A free, unhindered right of access: we have confidence to enter the sanctuary by the blood of Jesus (10:19). In 10:35 the same word returns: don't throw it away – like a soldier who throws away his shield and flees.

THE BIG IDEA

By one offering Christ has made perfect for all time those who are made holy; so let us approach God, hold fast to our hope and consider one another – and not throw away our confidence, for the one who is coming will come.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

If a medicine really cures, you stop taking it. “In these sacrifices there is a reminder of sins year after year” – but verse 18 says: “Where there is forgiveness of these, there is no longer any offering for sin.” Where do we set up little side altars next to the cross – punishing ourselves or doing penance before we accept forgiveness?

Hebrews 10:1–4

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“See, I have come to do your will.” God was looking not for mere rituals but for a body willing to do his will. What would it look like to put your everyday body – your time, your work, your family life – at his disposal this week?

Hebrews 10:5–10

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Every priest stands day after day; this one offered one sacrifice and took his seat. “For by one offering he has made perfect for all time those who are made holy.” How does this verse help when you are discouraged by how slowly you change?

Hebrews 10:11–18

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Verses 19–23 rest on two possessions – the open way and a great priest – and call us to approach and to hold fast, “for the one who made the promise is faithful”. Why does it matter that our holding on rests on his faithfulness rather than on the strength of our grip?

Hebrews 10:19–23

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“And let us consider one another, so as to spur one another on to love and good works.” The same verb is used in 3:1 for considering Jesus. What would it look like for us as a group to consider one another in this way – and who among us needs encouraging right now?

Hebrews 10:24–25

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Verses 26–31 are among the most serious words in the letter: “To fall into the hands of the living God is a fearful thing.” Yet straight after them the author writes: “But remember the earlier days”. Why do warning and encouragement belong together here?

Hebrews 10:26–31

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The readers had once accepted the loss of their possessions with joy, knowing they had a better possession, one that lasts. “So do not throw away your confidence, which has a great reward.” Which earlier struggle, through which God carried you, gives you courage for the present one?

Hebrews 10:32–39

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one side altar in your life – a way you try to pay for your own failures – and each time you notice it this week, read verse 18 and receive forgiveness instead.
- Consider one person this week – perhaps someone who has been missing from your meetings – and spur them on with a visit, a call or a message of encouragement.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verses 22–24 aloud together. Then pray in three movements: approach God with thanks for the open way through Jesus' blood; hold fast – bring to God the places where your hope is under pressure; consider one another – pray by name for one person in the group. Close together with verse 39.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 11

By Faith

Hebrews 11:1–40

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever paid for something long before you could enjoy it – a ticket, a plot of land, a holiday? What did it feel like to hold the proof in your hand while you were still waiting?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 10 the author reminded his tired, persecuted readers that they are not of those who draw back, but of those who have faith. Now he opens a gallery of witnesses from their own Scriptures – from Abel, Enoch and Noah, through Abraham and the patriarchs, to Moses, Rahab and nameless martyrs. None of them lived by what their eyes could see; all of them lived by God's promises. Tonight we read the whole of chapter 11.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:1–3

[1] Now faith is the assurance of what is hoped for, the proof of things that are not
seen. [2] For by it the people of old were attested. [3] By faith we understand that the
worlds were fashioned by God's word, so that what is seen did not come into being
out of things that appear.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:4–5

4 By faith Abel offered God a greater sacrifice than Cain. Through it he was attested
as righteous, God himself testifying about his gifts; and through it, though he died,
he is still speaking. 5 By faith Enoch was taken up so that he would not see death,
and "he was not found, because God had taken him up". For before he was taken up,
it was testified of him that he had pleased God.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:6–7

6 And without faith it is impossible to please him, for whoever approaches God must
believe that he exists and that he rewards those who earnestly seek him. 7 By faith
Noah, when he was warned by God about things not yet seen, in reverence built an
ark for the salvation of his house. Through it he condemned the world, and he
became heir of the righteousness that accords with faith.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:8–10

8 By faith Abraham obeyed when he was called to go out to a place that he was to
receive as an inheritance; and he went out, not knowing where he was going. 9 By
faith he lived as a guest in the land of the promise as in a foreign land, living in tents
with Isaac and Jacob, co-heirs of the same promise. 10 For he was waiting for the city
that has the foundations, whose designer and builder is God.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:11–12

11 By faith he received power to father offspring – together with Sarah herself – even
when he was past the age for it, since he considered the one who had promised
faithful. 12 Therefore from one man, and him as good as dead, descendants were
born as many as the stars of heaven and as countless as the sand on the shore of the
sea.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:13–15

13 In faith all these died without having received the promises, but they saw them
from afar and greeted them, and confessed that they were strangers and temporary
residents on the earth. 14 For people who speak like this make it clear that they are
seeking a homeland. 15 If they had been thinking of the one they had left, they
would have had opportunity to return.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:16–18

16 But as it is, they long for a better one, that is, a heavenly one. Therefore God is not
ashamed of them, to be called their God; for he has prepared a city for them.

17 By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac. He who had received the
promises was ready to offer up his only son, 18 he to whom it had been said,
"Through Isaac offspring will be named for you."

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:19–22

19 He reckoned that God is able even to raise from the dead; hence he did receive him
back – as a symbol. 20 By faith Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau, also concerning things
to come. 21 By faith Jacob, when he was dying, blessed each of the sons of Joseph,
and he worshipped, leaning on the top of his staff. 22 By faith Joseph, at the end of
his life, mentioned the exodus of the sons of Israel and gave instructions about his
bones.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:23–25

23 By faith Moses, after he was born, was hidden for three months by his parents,
because they saw that the child was beautiful, and they were not afraid of the king's
edict. 24 By faith Moses, when he had grown up, refused to be called the son of
Pharaoh's daughter, 25 choosing rather to be mistreated along with the people of
God than to have the fleeting enjoyment of sin,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:26–29

26 for he considered the reproach of the Christ greater wealth than the treasures of
Egypt, because he had his eyes fixed on the reward. 27 By faith he left Egypt, not
fearing the fury of the king; for he held on as though he saw the one who is
invisible. 28 By faith he instituted the Passover and the applying of the blood, so that
the destroyer of the firstborn would not touch them. 29 By faith they crossed the Red
Sea as on dry land; when the Egyptians attempted it, they were swallowed up.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:30–33

30 By faith the walls of Jericho fell after they had been encircled for seven days. 31 By faith Rahab the prostitute did not perish with those who disobeyed, because she had welcomed the spies in peace.

32 And what more shall I say? Time would fail me if I told of Gideon, Barak, Samson, Jephthah, of David and Samuel and the prophets, 33 who through faith conquered kingdoms, practised righteousness, obtained promises, shut the mouths of lions,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:34–36

34 quenched the power of fire, escaped the edge of the sword, were made strong out
of weakness, became mighty in war, put foreign armies to flight. 35 Women received
back their dead by resurrection. Others were tortured and refused to accept release,
so that they might obtain a better resurrection. 36 Still others experienced mocking
and flogging, and even chains and prison.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:37–39

37 They were stoned, they were sawn in two, they died by the sword; they went about
in sheepskins and goatskins, in want, afflicted, mistreated – 38 the world was not
worthy of them – wandering in deserts and mountains, in caves and holes in the
ground.

39 And all these, though they were attested through their faith, did not receive the
promise,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 11:40–40

40 since God had foreseen something better for us, so that they would not be made perfect apart from us.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ὑπόστασις

hypostasis · “assurance”

We met this word in 1:3 (“being”) and 3:14 (“assurance”). In some Greek papyri of the first centuries it is used for documents that prove ownership – a kind of title deed. Faith holds the title deed of God's promises before we have moved in (11:1).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀσπάζομαι

aspazomai · "greeted"

To welcome something with joy, to embrace it with open arms – like sailors who see the hills of home on the horizon and cheer, though they are still miles from the harbour. The patriarchs died without the fulfilment, but they saw the promises from afar and greeted them (11:13).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

καρτερέω

kartereō · “held on”

Like a soldier who stays standing, strong and unshaken. This is the secret of Moses' staying power: when you see the invisible King with the eye of faith, the fury of an earthly pharaoh shrinks to nothing (11:27).

THE BIG IDEA

Faith treats God's promises as a title deed in our hand: it makes us pilgrims on the way to the city whose builder is God, it values the reproach of the Christ above the treasures of Egypt, and it holds on – whether God delivers us or carries us through suffering.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

“Now faith is the assurance of what is hoped for, the proof of things that are not seen.” The devotional compares this assurance to a title deed. What is the difference between treating a promise of God as a title deed and treating it as a wish?

Hebrews 11:1–3

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Abel shows the worship of faith, Enoch its daily walk, Noah its work and perseverance. Verse 6 says that whoever approaches God must believe that he exists and that he “rewards those who earnestly seek him”. How does that picture of God change the way you pray?

Hebrews 11:4–7

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Abraham “went out, not knowing where he was going”. When have you had to take a step of obedience without seeing the whole map? What helped you take it?

Hebrews 11:8–12

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The patriarchs confessed that they were “strangers and temporary residents on the earth”. Where do we drive our tent pegs too deep into this world? And what does it mean to you that “God is not ashamed of them, to be called their God”?

Hebrews 11:13–16

DISCUSSION · 5/7

On Moriah Abraham “reckoned that God is able even to raise from the dead”. What is the “Isaac” in your life – a good gift from God that you may be clinging to more tightly than to the Giver?

Hebrews 11:17–22

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Moses “considered the reproach of the Christ greater wealth than the treasures of Egypt”. What are today's treasures of Egypt, and what helps us see through “the fleeting enjoyment of sin”?

Hebrews 11:23–28

DISCUSSION · 7/7

In verses 33–35 some shut the mouths of lions; then the text turns: “Others were tortured and refused to accept release”. Both groups stand in the same list, and of the suffering ones it says “the world was not worthy of them”. How can this help someone in a long, hard season?

Hebrews 11:32–40

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write down one promise of God you are holding on to without yet seeing it fulfilled. Read it every morning this week as a title deed, and thank God for it before you see anything change.
- Name one tent peg that holds you too tightly to this world – a possession, an ambition or a worry – and do one concrete thing this week to loosen it: give something away, share, or hand it over to God in prayer.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verse 1 aloud together. Thank God for the people of faith who went before you, in the Bible and in your own life. Then pray for anyone in the group who is in an “Others” season – waiting, suffering or not yet seeing an answer – and ask that all of you may hold on as those who see the invisible One.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 12

The Race and the Mountain

Hebrews 12:1–29

TO GET STARTED

Think of a time you finished something long and hard – a race, a climb, a project – when you felt like giving up halfway. What kept you going?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 11 ended with a great gallery of witnesses; now the baton is placed in our hands. The first readers were worn out, like long-distance runners with a cramp halfway through a marathon. In chapter 12 the author gives them new strength with three pictures: a stadium (verses 1–3), a family home where children are raised (verses 4–13), and two mountains – Sinai and Zion (verses 18–24) – followed by the last warning of the letter (verses 25–29).

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:1–2

[1] Therefore, since we too have such a vast cloud of witnesses surrounding us, let us lay aside every weight and the sin that so readily wraps itself around us, and let us run with endurance the race that lies before us, [2] with our eyes fixed on Jesus, the pioneer of faith and the one who brings it to perfection. For the sake of the joy that lay before him he endured the cross, despising the shame, and he has taken his seat at the right hand of the throne of God.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:3–5

3 Consider him who endured such opposition from sinners against themselves, so
that you do not grow weary and lose heart in your souls.

4 In your struggle against sin you have not yet resisted to the point of blood, 5 and
you have forgotten the encouragement that addresses you as sons:

My son, do not make light of the discipline of the Lord,
and do not lose heart when you are corrected by him;

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:6–8

6 for the Lord disciplines the one he loves,
and he flogs every son whom he accepts.
7 It is for discipline that you endure. God is treating you as sons. For what son is there whom a father does not discipline? 8 But if you are without the discipline that all have come to share in, then you are illegitimate and not sons.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:9–11

9 Besides, we had the fathers of our flesh to discipline us, and we respected them.
Shall we not much more submit to the Father of spirits and live? 10 For they
disciplined us for a few days as seemed good to them, but he does it for our good, so
that we may share in his holiness. 11 All discipline, for the moment, seems to be a
matter not of joy but of sorrow; later, however, it yields the peaceful fruit of
righteousness to those who have been trained by it.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:12–15

12 Therefore lift up again the drooping hands and the weakened knees, 13 and make
straight paths for your feet, so that what is lame may not be put out of joint but
rather be healed.

14 Pursue peace with everyone, and holiness, without which no one will see the
Lord. 15 See to it that no one falls short of the grace of God, that no root of bitterness
springs up and causes trouble, and through it many are defiled,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:16–18

16 that no one is sexually immoral or godless like Esau, who sold his birthright for a
single meal. 17 For you know that later, when he wanted to inherit the blessing, he
was rejected; for he found no place for repentance, although he sought it with tears.

18 For you have not approached something that could be touched, and blazing fire,
and darkness and gloom and storm,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:19–22

19 and the sound of a trumpet and a voice speaking words, whose hearers begged
that no further word be spoken to them, 20 for they could not bear the command,
"Even if an animal touches the mountain, it shall be stoned." 21 And so terrifying was
the sight that Moses said, "I am full of fear and trembling." 22 But you have
approached Mount Zion and the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem, and
myriads of angels, the festal gathering

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:23–25

23 and assembly of the firstborn who are enrolled in the heavens, and God, the judge
of all, and the spirits of the righteous who have been made perfect, 24 and Jesus, the
mediator of a new covenant, and the blood of sprinkling that speaks better than
Abel.

25 See that you do not refuse the one who is speaking. For if they did not escape
when they refused the one who warned them on earth, much less shall we, if we
turn away from the one who warns from heaven.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:26–28

26 His voice shook the earth then, but now he has promised:

Once more I will shake not only the earth
but also heaven.
27 This "Once more" shows that what is shaken will be removed, as things that have been made, so that what is not shaken may remain. 28 Therefore, since we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, let us be thankful, and so worship God in a way that pleases him, with reverence and awe;

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 12:29–29

29 for our God is indeed a consuming fire.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀφορῶντες

aphorōntes · “with our eyes fixed on”

The prefix apo- (away from) means that you deliberately turn your eyes away from everything else to fix them on one point: Jesus, “the pioneer of faith and the one who brings it to perfection” (12:2). No runner wins by looking at his own feet or at the crowd.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

παιδεία

paideia · "discipline"

From pais (child): the whole process of raising a child, forming character and loving correction. A court's punishment looks back at the offence in order to repay it – and our punishment has already fallen on Jesus; the Father's paideia looks forward to the child's growth (12:5–11).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

πανήγυρις

panēgyris · “festal gathering”

A great national festival, as at the Olympic Games when the whole city celebrated. At Sinai the angels surrounded the awe-inspiring giving of the law; at Zion they celebrate the redemption of sinners (12:22).

THE BIG IDEA

With our eyes fixed on Jesus we run the race with endurance and accept the Father's discipline as love; and because we have approached Mount Zion, not Sinai, we receive a kingdom that cannot be shaken and worship God with gratitude, reverence and awe.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

We have “such a vast cloud of witnesses surrounding us” – not spectators waiting for us to fall, but witnesses who testify through their own race that God's promises hold. Which “weight” – perhaps not even a sin – is slowing you down at the moment?

Hebrews 12:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“For the sake of the joy that lay before him he endured the cross, despising the shame.” What does it mean in practice to keep your eyes fixed on Jesus when you feel overwhelmed by opposition, injustice or your own weakness?

Hebrews 12:2–3

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Verse 5 warns against two opposite reactions to hardship: “do not make light of the discipline of the Lord” and “do not lose heart”. Which of the two is more your tendency? How does it change things to see hardship as the Father's training rather than his punishment?

Hebrews 12:4–10

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“Later, however, it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it.” Can you tell of a hard season in which you only saw the fruit later?

Hebrews 12:11–13

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Esau “sold his birthright for a single meal”, and a root of bitterness can defile many. What “single meal” tempts us today? And how can we, as a group, “see to it” for one another without becoming judgemental?

Hebrews 12:14–17

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Compare the two mountains: what do you see, hear and feel at Sinai (verses 18–21) and at Zion (verses 22–24)? When you pray, do you approach God more like Sinai or like Zion?

Hebrews 12:18–24

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The blood of Jesus “speaks better than Abel”, and “since we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, let us be thankful”. What is being shaken around you at the moment, and what would thankful worship look like as your answer?

Hebrews 12:24–29

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one “weight” and put it down this week in a concrete way – an evening without a screen, a commitment you hand back, a worry you give to God in prayer each morning.
- If a root of bitterness has begun to grow towards someone, take one step this week towards peace: pray for that person by name, send a message, or ask for a conversation.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verse 2 aloud together. Keep a minute of silence in which each person lays down a weight before God. Then pray for those in the group who feel tired in the race, thank God that in Christ we have approached Mount Zion, and close by reading verses 28–29 together.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 13

The Great Shepherd

Hebrews 13:1–25

TO GET STARTED

When a long time together comes to an end – a trip, a course, a job – what do you most want the others to take with them?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 12 the author said that we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken and should worship God with thankfulness, reverence and awe. Chapter 13 shows what that worship looks like on an ordinary weekday: love, hospitality, marriage and money (verses 1–6), leaders and the unchanging Christ (7–9), going out to Jesus outside the camp (10–14), the sacrifices of praise and sharing (15–19), and finally a great blessing and personal greetings (20–25). Tonight we finish the letter – and this series.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 13:1–4

1 Let love for one another as brothers and sisters continue. 2 Do not forget to show
hospitality to strangers, for by doing so some have entertained angels without
knowing it. 3 Remember those in prison as though you were in prison with them,
and those who are mistreated, since you yourselves also are in the body. 4 Let
marriage be held in honour by all, and the marriage bed be kept undefiled; for God
will judge the sexually immoral and adulterers.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 13:5–7

5 Let your way of life be free from the love of money; be content with what you have.
For he himself has said, "I will never let you go and never abandon you." 6 So we can
say with courage:

The Lord is my helper, I will not be afraid.
What can a human being do to me?
7 Remember your leaders, who spoke the word of God to you. Consider the outcome
of their way of life, and imitate their faith.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 13:8–11

8 Jesus Christ is yesterday and today the same – and for ever. 9 Do not be carried away
by all kinds of strange teachings; for it is good for the heart to be strengthened by
grace, not by foods, which have not benefited those who lived by them. 10 We have
an altar from which those who worship at the tent have no right to eat. 11 For the
bodies of the animals whose blood is brought by the high priest into the sanctuary
for sin are burned outside the camp.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 13:12–15

12 That is why Jesus too suffered outside the gate, in order to make the people holy
through his own blood. 13 So let us go out to him outside the camp, bearing his
reproach. 14 For here we have no city that lasts; rather, we are seeking the one that is
to come. 15 Through him, then, let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God,
that is, the fruit of lips that confess his name.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 13:16–18

16 Do not forget to do good and to share, for with such sacrifices God is pleased.

17 Listen to your leaders and defer to them, for they keep watch over your souls as people who will give account. Let them do this with joy and not with groaning, for that would be of no benefit to you. 18 Pray for us; for we are convinced that we have a good conscience, wanting to live well in every respect.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 13:19–21

19 I encourage you all the more to do this, so that I may be restored to you sooner.

20 Now may the God of peace, who brought up from the dead the great shepherd of the sheep by the blood of an eternal covenant, our Lord Jesus, 21 equip you with everything good to do his will, working in us what is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory for ever. Amen.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 13:22–25

22 I encourage you, brothers and sisters: bear with this word of encouragement, for I
have written to you only briefly. 23 You should know that our brother Timothy has
been released; if he comes soon, I will see you with him. 24 Greet all your leaders and
all the saints. Those from Italy greet you. 25 Grace be with you all.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

οὐ μή σε ἀνῶ οὐδ’ οὐ μή σε ἐγκαταλίπω

ou mē se anō oud' ou mē se enkatalipō · “never … never”

In 13:5 the Greek piles up five negatives: freely rendered: I will never, ever loosen my grip on you, and I will never, ever abandon you. Our security lies not in what we have, but in whom we have – that is why we can be content (13:5–6).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἔξω τῆς παρεμβολῆς

exō tēs parembolēs · “outside the camp”

On the Day of Atonement the bodies of the sin offerings were burned outside the camp (Leviticus 16:27). Jesus suffered outside the gate. For the first readers the camp was the safe, respected world of the temple – but Jesus is outside (13:11–13).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

καταρτίζω

katartizō · "equip"

Used in medicine for setting a broken bone and by fishermen for mending nets (Matthew 4:21); in 11:3 the same verb describes the worlds being fashioned by God's word. What God asks of us, he himself works in us (13:21).

THE BIG IDEA

Grateful worship in a kingdom that cannot be shaken becomes practical love, contentment and the courage to go out to Jesus outside the camp; we offer God the sacrifices of praise and sharing – and the God of peace, who brought up the great shepherd from the dead, himself equips us to do his will.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Verses 1–4 name four directions of love: love for brothers and sisters, hospitality to strangers, compassion for prisoners and the mistreated, and honour for marriage. Which of these is strong in our group, and which needs our attention?

Hebrews 13:1–4

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“Be content with what you have” – and the reason given is not a budget but a promise: “I will never let you go and never abandon you.” Why does contentment rest on a person rather than on possessions? Where are you uneasy about money or the future?

Hebrews 13:5–6

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“Jesus Christ is yesterday and today the same – and for ever.” Think of your own yesterday, today and future: where do you most need to hear this sentence?

Hebrews 13:7–8

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“It is good for the heart to be strengthened by grace, not by foods.” What are today's “foods” – rules, achievements or forms we use to feel in control? What does it look like to let grace strengthen your heart?

Hebrews 13:9

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“So let us go out to him outside the camp, bearing his reproach.” What is the comfortable “camp” in our setting, and what could going out to Jesus look like for you this month?

Hebrews 13:10–14

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Verses 15–16 name two sacrifices: “the fruit of lips that confess his name” and “Do not forget to do good and to share”. Which comes more naturally to you – the lips or the hands? And how can we make the work of those who “keep watch over your souls” a joy rather than a groaning?

Hebrews 13:15–19

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Looking back over the whole series: Hebrews has shown us Jesus as the Son through whom God has spoken, the merciful high priest, the forerunner, the pioneer of faith and now the great shepherd. Which picture of Jesus has become most important to you, and why?

Hebrews 13:20–21

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one of the directions of love in verses 1–3 and put it into practice this week: invite someone for a meal, visit or write to someone in prison, hospital or a care home, or share something you have with someone in need.
- As the series ends, choose the one verse from Hebrews that has spoken to you most. Write it out, put it where you will see it every day, and tell one person this week why it matters to you.

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God together for what he has done in the group through this series. Pray for your leaders and for one another, as the author asks in verse 18. Close by turning to one another and speaking verses 20–21 as a blessing over the group, and end with the last words of the letter: “Grace be with you all.”

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 2

Do Not Drift

Hebrews 2:1–18

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever been on a lilo, a boat or a paddleboard and suddenly noticed how far the current had carried you without your noticing? What happened?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 1 showed the Son exalted far above the angels. Now the author turns to the first of five warning passages: if the word spoken through angels at Sinai was binding, how much more the salvation the Lord himself spoke of (vv. 1–4). Then he answers a stumbling block for his Jewish readers – why would the Son become a frail human being and die? – with Psalm 8, showing Jesus as our pioneer, our brother and our high priest (vv. 5–18).

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 2:1–3

[1] That is why we must pay much closer attention to what we have heard, so that we
do not drift away. [2] For if the word spoken through angels proved binding, and every
transgression and disobedience received a just penalty, [3] how shall we escape if we
disregard a salvation this great? It began when the Lord spoke of it, and it was
confirmed to us by those who heard,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 2:4–6

4 while God added his testimony by signs and wonders and various mighty works
and by distributions of the Holy Spirit according to his will.

5 For it was not to angels that he subjected the world to come, about which we are
speaking. 6 Rather, someone has testified somewhere:

What is a human being, that you remember him,
or a son of man, that you look after him?

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 2:7–8

7 You made him a little lower than the angels;
with glory and honour you crowned him;
8 you subjected everything under his feet.
For in subjecting everything to him, he left nothing that is not subject to him. As it
is, we do not yet see everything subjected to him.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 2:9–10

9 But we do see the one who was made a little lower than the angels, Jesus, crowned with glory and honour because of the suffering of death, so that by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone.

10 For it was fitting for him, for whose sake everything exists and through whom everything exists, in bringing many sons to glory, to make the pioneer of their salvation perfect through sufferings.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 2:11–13

11 For the one who makes holy and those who are made holy are all from one. That is
why he is not ashamed to call them brothers and sisters, 12 saying:

I will declare your name to my brothers and sisters;
in the midst of the assembly I will sing your praise.
13 And again:

I will put my trust in him.
And again:
See, here am I, and the children God has given me.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 2:14–16

14 Since, then, the children share in blood and flesh, he too in the same way took
part in the same things, so that through death he might break the power of the one
who holds sway over death, that is, the devil, 15 and set free all those who through
fear of death were held in slavery all their lives. 16 For surely he does not take hold of
angels; it is the offspring of Abraham he takes hold of.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 2:17–18

17 Therefore he had to be made like the brothers and sisters in every respect, so that
he might become a merciful and faithful high priest before God, to make atonement
for the sins of the people. 18 For because he himself suffered when he was tested, he
is able to help those who are being tested.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

παραρυῶμεν

pararyōmen · “drift away”

A seafaring word for a boat that has not been properly moored and quietly drifts with the current past the safe harbour – or a ring that slips unnoticed off a finger. Its opposite in the same verse, prosechein (pay attention), meant holding a ship on course and mooring it. The danger is not sudden rebellion but slow, unnoticed drifting (2:1).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀρχηγός

archēgos · “pioneer”

A pioneer, trailblazer or champion – like the sailor in a well-known sermon illustration who swims through the breakers to the rocky shore and ties a rescue line, so that everyone on board can cross safely. God made this pioneer “perfect through sufferings”: teleioō means fully qualified for his task, not morally improved (2:10).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

βοηθέω

boētheō · "help"

Made up of boē (a cry for help) and theō (to run): to rush towards a cry for help. Because he himself suffered when he was tested, Jesus "is able to help those who are being tested" (2:18).

THE BIG IDEA

Because the Son is so great, we must not drift away from a salvation this great: Jesus became one of us, tasted death for everyone by the grace of God, broke the power of the devil, and is now the merciful and faithful high priest who helps us when we are tested.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

“How shall we escape if we disregard a salvation this great?” The danger here is not open rebellion but drifting through tiredness and neglect. Which undercurrents in our daily lives pull our attention away from the Lord?

Hebrews 2:1–3

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Verses 3–4 give a threefold foundation for this salvation: the Lord who first spoke of it, those who heard him, and God who added his testimony. Why does it help to know that our faith rests on this testimony and not on our feelings?

Hebrews 2:3–4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“As it is, we do not yet see everything subjected to him.” Where do you feel this most painfully – in the world, in your family, in yourself?

Hebrews 2:5–8

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“But we do see … Jesus, crowned with glory and honour.” What changes when we shift our gaze from what we do not yet see to the one we do see by faith?

Hebrews 2:8–9

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Jesus was made a little lower than the angels “so that by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone”. He did not merely dip his fingertips into death; he drained the cup. What does that mean to you?

Hebrews 2:9

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“He is not ashamed to call them brothers and sisters.” When do you feel like the black sheep of God's family? How does verse 11 speak into that?

Hebrews 2:10–13

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Verse 15 speaks of people “held in slavery all their lives” through fear of death, and verse 18 promises help to “those who are being tested”. Where does fear – of illness, loss, the future – dictate our decisions? And when you are tempted, do you fight alone first, or call on your high priest straight away?

Hebrews 2:14–18

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Check your anchor points: choose one daily habit you have let slip (stillness before the Lord, reading the word, fellowship with believers) and moor yourself to it again this week.
- When temptation or fear comes this week, make verse 18 your first response: call to Jesus at once with a short prayer for help, before you try to fight it in your own strength.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 17–18 aloud together. Pray in threes: confess where you have been drifting, thank Jesus that he is not ashamed to call you his brother or sister, and bring him one area where fear or temptation is pressing on you. Close by praying for people you know who are drifting away.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 3

Today

Hebrews 3:1–19

TO GET STARTED

Think of something you kept putting off until tomorrow – a phone call, a repair, a conversation. What happened in the end?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

After the prophets and the angels, the author now comes to the greatest figure in Israel's history: Moses. He honours Moses as faithful, then shows that Jesus is the builder and the Son over the house (vv. 1–6). Then he opens the second warning passage with Psalm 95: the generation that saw God's works for forty years still could not enter his rest because of unbelief (vv. 7–19).

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 3:1–3

[1] Therefore, holy brothers and sisters, partners in a heavenly calling, consider
closely the apostle and high priest of our confession, Jesus. [2] He is faithful to the one
who appointed him, as Moses also was in his house. [3] For he has been counted
worthy of greater glory than Moses, just as the builder of a house has greater
honour than the house itself.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 3:4–7

4 For every house is built by someone, but the one who built all things is God.
5 Moses was faithful in all his house as a servant, to testify to the things that were to
be spoken later, 6 but Christ as a Son over his house. And we are his house, if we hold
fast to the confidence and the pride we take in hope.

7 Therefore, as the Holy Spirit says:

Today, if you hear his voice,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 3:8–9

8 do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion,
on the day of testing in the wilderness,
9 where your fathers tested me and put me to the proof
and saw my works

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 3:10–11

10 for forty years.
Therefore I was indignant with this generation
and said: They always go astray in their heart;
they have not known my ways.
11 So I swore in my anger:
They shall never enter my rest!

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 3:12–15

12 Take care, brothers and sisters, that none of you has an evil heart full of unbelief
that falls away from the living God. 13 Rather, encourage one another every day, as
long as it is called "Today", so that none of you is hardened by the deceitfulness of
sin. 14 For we have become partners of Christ – if indeed we hold the assurance we
had at the beginning firm to the end. 15 As it is said:

Today, if you hear his voice,
do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 3:16–19

16 who, then, were they who heard and yet rebelled? Was it not all those who came
out of Egypt led by Moses? 17 And with whom was he indignant for forty years? Was
it not with those who sinned, whose corpses fell in the wilderness? 18 And to whom
did he swear that they would not enter his rest, if not to those who disobeyed? 19 So
we see that they could not enter because of unbelief.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

κατανοήσατε

katanoēsate · “consider closely”

Not a quick glance, but fixing your thoughts deeply on something, studying it carefully and getting to the bottom of it. The object is Jesus in his double office as apostle and high priest – the only place in the New Testament where he is called an apostle (3:1).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

θεράπων

therapōn · "servant"

Not the ordinary word for a slave (doulos) but an honourable word for a trusted servant and confidant of his master (Numbers 12:7). Moses was faithful in the house as a servant; Christ is faithful as a Son over the house – the heir to whom the whole house belongs (3:5–6).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

σκληρύνω

sklērynō · "harden"

The source of the medical term sclerosis: something soft and living gradually stiffens and becomes numb. It happens through the deceitfulness of sin (apatē), which never comes with a warning label (3:8, 13, 15).

THE BIG IDEA

Jesus, the Son over God's house, is greater than Moses, the faithful servant in it – so we consider him closely, do not harden our hearts when he speaks today, and encourage one another every day, because holding fast to the end shows that we have truly become partners of Christ.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

“Consider closely the apostle and high priest of our confession, Jesus.” What gets your deepest attention on an ordinary day – and what would it look like to consider Jesus closely this week?

Hebrews 3:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Moses was faithful as a servant in the house; Christ is faithful “as a Son over his house”. The author honours Moses and does not run him down. Which servants in the house – leaders, traditions, churches – are we tempted to build our security on instead of on the Son?

Hebrews 3:2–6

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“And we are his house.” What does it mean for our group – and for you personally – that God's house is no longer a building of stone but his people?

Hebrews 3:6

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The author introduces Psalm 95 with “as the Holy Spirit says” – in the present tense. Is there an area where the Spirit has been speaking to your conscience, while you keep saying: not today, Lord?

Hebrews 3:7–11

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The exodus generation saw God's works for forty years and still went astray in their heart. How does hardening happen gradually – and how does “the deceitfulness of sin” work in practice?

Hebrews 3:8–13

DISCUSSION · 6/7

God's remedy is shared: “encourage one another every day”. Who has the freedom to speak God's truth into your life – and whom could you encourage this week?

Hebrews 3:13

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“For we have become partners of Christ – if indeed we hold the assurance we had at the beginning firm to the end.” How does this verse comfort us, and how does it challenge us?

Hebrews 3:14–19

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Take one matter where you have been putting God off until tomorrow, and obey this week – today.
- Encourage one believer every day this week – a message, a call or a word in person that points them to the faithfulness of Christ.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 7–8 aloud together. Pray in pairs: ask the Lord for a soft heart that answers when he calls, name one place where you need to obey today, and pray for each other by name. Close by thanking God together that we are his house.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 4

The Promise of Rest

Hebrews 4:1–16

TO GET STARTED

What does real rest look like for you – not just sleep, but the kind that leaves you truly refreshed? When did you last have it?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 3 ended with the wilderness generation that could not enter because of unbelief. Now the author brings the warning into the present: the promise of entering God's rest still stands. He links three Old Testament crossroads – God's rest on the seventh day, Joshua and Canaan, and the “Today” of Psalm 95 (vv. 1–11) – then shows the living word that judges the heart (vv. 12–13), and the great high priest who opens the way to the throne of grace (vv. 14–16).

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 4:1–3

[1] So, since the promise of entering his rest still stands, let us fear that any of you
should seem to have fallen short. [2] For we too have had the good news proclaimed to
us, just as they did; but the word they heard did not benefit them, because they
were not united by faith with those who truly heard. [3] For we who have believed are
entering the rest, just as he has said:

So I swore in my anger:
They shall never enter my rest!
And yet the works had been finished since the foundation of the world.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 4:4–7

4 For somewhere he has spoken about the seventh day like this: "And God rested on
the seventh day from all his works." 5 And again in this passage: "They shall never
enter my rest!" 6 Since, then, it remains for some to enter it, and those who first had
the good news proclaimed to them did not enter because of disobedience, 7 he again
sets a certain day – "Today" – speaking through David so long afterwards, as has
been said before:

Today, if you hear his voice,
do not harden your hearts.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 4:8–11

8 For if Joshua had given them rest, he would not have spoken afterwards of another
day. 9 So then, a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God; 10 for whoever has
entered his rest has also rested from his own works, as God did from his. 11 Let us
therefore make every effort to enter that rest, so that no one falls by following the
same example of disobedience.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 4:12–14

12 For the word of God is living and effective and sharper than any double-edged
sword; it pierces through to the dividing of soul and spirit, of joints and marrow,
and it judges the thoughts and purposes of the heart. 13 And no creature is hidden
before him, but all things are naked and laid bare to the eyes of the one to whom we
must give account.

14 Since, then, we have a great high priest who has passed through the heavens,
Jesus, the Son of God, let us hold fast to the confession.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 4:15–16

15 For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our
weaknesses, but one who has been tested in every respect in the same way – yet
without sin. 16 Let us therefore approach the throne of grace with confidence, so
that we may receive mercy and find grace as help at the right time.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

σαββατισμός

sabbatismos · "Sabbath rest"

Throughout chapters 3–4 the author uses katapausis (rest, a place of rest, such as Canaan). In 4:9 he uses this very rare word for a true, festive Sabbath rest – Hebrews is the earliest known place it occurs, and the author may have coined it. Joshua (in Greek Iēsous, the same name as Jesus) could give only an earthly shadow-rest; the true Jesus brings us into God's own rest.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

τετραχηλισμένα

tetrachēlismena · “laid bare”

From trachēlos, neck or throat. In ancient wrestling the verb described a hold that bent the opponent's head back so that he could not look away; some also see an echo of the sacrificial animal inspected by the priest. Before God's eyes all things are “naked and laid bare” (4:13).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

συμπαθέω

sympatheō · “sympathize”

Far stronger than our word sympathy: literally to suffer with someone from the inside. Jesus “has been tested in every respect in the same way – yet without sin”. Because he never gave in, he felt the full force of temptation (4:15).

THE BIG IDEA

A Sabbath rest remains for the people of God: we enter it by faith, not by our own works, under the living word that lays our hearts bare – and we can approach the throne of grace with confidence, because our great high priest sympathizes with our weaknesses.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

“The word they heard did not benefit them, because they were not united by faith with those who truly heard.” The devotional compares this to a meal that is eaten but never digested. How can we hear God's word without it changing us?

Hebrews 4:1–2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Joshua brought Israel into a land, but not into God's final rest; “a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God”. What is this rest – and in which area of your life are you still on a spiritual treadmill, working for God's approval instead of living from it?

Hebrews 4:3–10

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“Let us therefore make every effort to enter that rest.” How can it take effort to rest? What does the fight of faith look like for you?

Hebrews 4:11

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The word of God is “living and effective and sharper than any double-edged sword”. When has a passage of Scripture cut through your excuses? How do you respond when it touches a sore or hidden place?

Hebrews 4:12

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“All things are naked and laid bare to the eyes of the one to whom we must give account.” Is that frightening or freeing for you – and why do you think the author follows it immediately with verse 14?

Hebrews 4:13–14

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“We do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses.” Some think that because Jesus never sinned, he cannot really know how hard temptation is. Why does the devotional say the opposite is true?

Hebrews 4:15

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“Let us therefore approach the throne of grace with confidence.” When you have failed, do you picture God's throne as a judge's bench to hide from or as a throne of grace to run to? What do you need today – mercy for the past, or grace for the present?

Hebrews 4:16

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one area where you are restlessly trying to carry the outcome in your own strength. Each day this week, hand it over to the Lord on purpose and rest in Christ's finished work.
- When you fail or are tempted this week, don't wait until you have cleaned yourself up: go straight to the throne of grace with a short, honest prayer for mercy and grace.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verse 16 aloud together. Then keep a moment of silence before the living word, and let each person ask the Lord what he wants to lay bare. Pray in pairs for mercy and for help at the right time, and close by praying verse 16 over one another.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 5

Our Understanding High Priest

Hebrews 5:1–14

TO GET STARTED

Think of a time when someone helped you who had been through the same thing themselves. What made their help different?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 4 ended with an invitation to approach the throne of grace with confidence, because we have a great high priest who can sympathize with our weaknesses (4:14–16). Chapter 5 now explains what makes a true high priest: he is taken from among human beings and called by God – and Jesus fulfils both, right through the tears of Gethsemane. Then the author suddenly stops: before he can say more about Melchizedek, he has to deal with his readers' dull hearing.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 5:1–3

[1] For every high priest is taken from among human beings and appointed on behalf
of human beings in what is to be done before God, to offer gifts and sacrifices for
sins. [2] He is able to deal gently with those who are ignorant and going astray, since
he himself is beset with weakness. [3] Because of this he must offer sacrifices for sins
for himself as well as for the people.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 5:4–6

4 And no one takes this honour for himself; he is called by God, just as Aaron was.

5 So also Christ did not glorify himself to become high priest; it was the one who said to him:

You are my Son;
today I have fathered you,
6 as he also says in another place:

You are a priest for ever
according to the order of Melchizedek.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 5:7–9

7 In the days of his flesh he offered up prayers and pleas with loud cries and tears to
the one who was able to save him out of death, and he was heard because of his
reverence. 8 Although he was a Son, he learned obedience through what he suffered;
9 and having been made perfect, he became the source of eternal salvation for all
who obey him,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 5:10–12

10 addressed by God as high priest according to the order of Melchizedek.

11 About this we have much to say, and it is hard to explain, since you have become
sluggish in hearing. 12 For though by this time you ought to be teachers, you again
need someone to teach you the first basics of the words of God; you have become
people who need milk, not solid food.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 5:13–14

13 For everyone who still lives on milk is unacquainted with the word of
righteousness, for he is an infant. 14 But solid food is for the mature, whose faculties
have been trained by practice to distinguish good from evil.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

μετριοπαθεῖν

metriopathein · "deal gently"

To keep one's emotions in measure: neither flaring up in anger at those who stumble nor turning away from them coldly. An earthly high priest needed this because he himself was beset with weakness (5:2); Christ had no sin of his own, yet shows perfect gentleness towards sinners.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἔμαθεν ἀφ᾽ ὧν ἔπαθεν

emathen aph' hōn epathen · “he learned obedience through what he suffered”

A wordplay: he learned (emathen) through what he suffered (epathen). As the eternal Son, Jesus was never disobedient; but as a human being he learned by experience what it costs to stay obedient when obedience costs everything. So he was made perfect – fully qualified – and became the source of eternal salvation (5:8–9).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

γεγυμνασμένα

gegymnasmena · “trained”

From gymnazō, which gives us gymnastics and gymnasium. Maturity is not how much we know but faculties trained by practice (hexis, repeated habit) to distinguish good from evil – discernment is built up like muscle, not learned overnight in a classroom (5:14).

THE BIG IDEA

Jesus did not take the honour of high priest for himself: called by God, he learned obedience through what he suffered and became the source of eternal salvation – and he calls us on from milk to solid food, to a faith trained by practice.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Verses 1–4 name two things every high priest needs: he is “taken from among human beings” and “called by God”. Why do both matter for someone who is to stand between us and God?

Hebrews 5:1–4

DISCUSSION · 2/7

An earthly high priest could “deal gently with those who are ignorant and going astray, since he himself is beset with weakness”. When have you met gentleness like that – neither harsh nor indifferent? What makes it hard to show?

Hebrews 5:2

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“Christ did not glorify himself to become high priest.” What does it tell us about Jesus that he did not seize this honour but received it from the Father (Psalm 2:7; Psalm 110:4)?

Hebrews 5:4–6

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Verse 7 takes us to Gethsemane: “prayers and pleas with loud cries and tears”. What does it mean for your own prayers that Jesus prayed like this? Do you dare to pray that honestly?

Hebrews 5:7

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“Although he was a Son, he learned obedience through what he suffered.” Jesus was never disobedient – so what did he learn? And what might God be teaching you in a hard season right now?

Hebrews 5:8–10

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The readers had “become sluggish in hearing” – they had not always been like this. How does a believer drift into spiritual sluggishness, and what are the early signs?

Hebrews 5:11–13

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Maturity, says verse 14, belongs to those “whose faculties have been trained by practice to distinguish good from evil”. What would your spiritual gym look like this week?

Hebrews 5:14

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Bring one honest, unpolished prayer to God this week – your real fears and needs, as Jesus prayed “with loud cries and tears” – and remember that your high priest understands.
- Choose one truth you already know (to forgive, to speak the truth when it costs you, to serve someone) and put it into practice in one concrete situation – one session in the spiritual gym.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 7–9 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: thank Jesus that he knows weakness and tears from the inside, name one place where you need his help right now, and ask him to train you to distinguish good from evil. Close by praying for anyone in the group who is going through a hard season.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 6

The Soul's Anchor

Hebrews 6:1–20

TO GET STARTED

Think of something you once had to wait a long time for. What helped you keep going – or what made you want to give up?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 5 the author stopped to rebuke his readers: they had become sluggish in hearing and still needed milk. Chapter 6 calls them on to maturity (vv. 1–3) and then gives one of the sternest warnings in the letter (vv. 4–8). But straight away he calls them “dear friends” and assures them of better things (vv. 9–12), before pointing them to God's oath to Abraham and to the hope that is an anchor of the soul (vv. 13–20).

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 6:1–3

1 So let us leave behind the elementary word about Christ and be carried on to
maturity, not laying again a foundation of repentance from dead works and of faith
in God, 2 of teaching about washings and laying on of hands, about the resurrection
of the dead and eternal judgment. 3 And this we will do, if indeed God permits.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 6:4–6

4 For it is impossible for those who have once been enlightened, who have tasted the
heavenly gift and have become partners of the Holy Spirit, 5 who have tasted the
goodness of the word of God and the powers of the age to come, 6 and who have
fallen away, to be renewed again to repentance – crucifying the Son of God again for
themselves and holding him up to contempt.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 6:7–9

7 For land that drinks the rain that often falls on it, and produces vegetation useful
to those for whose sake it is cultivated, receives a blessing from God. 8 But if it bears
thorns and thistles, it fails the test and is close to being cursed, and its end is to be
burned.

9 But even though we speak like this, dear friends, we are convinced of better things
in your case, things that belong to salvation.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 6:10–12

10 For God is not unjust; he will not forget your work and the love you have shown
for his name when you served the saints, as you still serve them. 11 And we long for
each one of you to show the same eagerness for the full assurance of hope to the
end, 12 so that you do not become sluggish, but imitate those who through faith and
patience inherit the promises.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 6:13–16

13 For when God made his promise to Abraham, since he had no one greater by
whom to swear, he swore by himself, 14 saying: "I will surely bless you and surely
multiply you." 15 And so, after waiting patiently, Abraham obtained the promise.
16 For people swear by someone greater than themselves, and for them an oath is the
end of every dispute, as confirmation.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 6:17–19

17 In the same way God, wanting to show even more clearly to the heirs of the
promise how unchangeable his purpose was, guaranteed it with an oath, 18 so that
through two unchangeable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who
have fled for refuge might have strong encouragement to hold fast to the hope set
before us. 19 We have this hope as an anchor of the soul, sure and firm, and it enters
the inner place behind the curtain,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 6:20–20

20 where Jesus has entered as a forerunner on our behalf, having become high priest
for ever according to the order of Melchizedek.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

νωθροί

nōthroi · "sluggish"

Dull, listless, numb. The word frames the passage: in 5:11 the readers have "become sluggish in hearing", and in 6:12 the author urges them not to become sluggish but to imitate those who inherit the promises. Its opposite is eagerness, faith and patience (makrothymia, a long breath).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀμετάθετος

ametathetos · “unchangeable”

A word used in legal language for a will or agreement that cannot be cancelled or altered. God's word was already enough, but for the sake of our doubt he added an oath – two unchangeable things, “in which it is impossible for God to lie” (6:17–18).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

πρόδρομος

prodromos · “forerunner”

Under the old covenant the high priest went behind the curtain alone, once a year, and no one could follow him. Jesus has entered “as a forerunner on our behalf”: he has gone ahead to open the way, so that we may follow him into God's presence (6:20).

THE BIG IDEA

Don't stand still at the foundation: the author warns earnestly against falling away, yet he is convinced of better things for his readers – and our hope rests on God's promise and God's oath, an anchor fixed behind the curtain where Jesus has gone ahead of us.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Verses 1–2 name six foundation stones in three pairs. Which of them were laid well in your own life? Why must we not keep laying the foundation again – and what does “if indeed God permits” add?

Hebrews 6:1–3

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Verses 4–5 describe people who “have once been enlightened” and “have tasted the heavenly gift”. How can someone experience so much at close quarters and still turn away? (Think of the wilderness generation in chapter 3.)

Hebrews 6:4–5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Verse 6 describes people who keep on “crucifying the Son of God again for themselves and holding him up to contempt”. Why does it matter that the impossibility is tied to an ongoing rejection of Jesus, the only high priest and the only sacrifice?

Hebrews 6:6

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Two pieces of land drink the same rain: one produces useful vegetation, the other thorns and thistles. What does the spiritual rain in your life look like, and what is it producing?

Hebrews 6:7–8

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Right after the warning the author says: “we are convinced of better things in your case”. What does he see in his readers (v. 10)? Where do you see “things that belong to salvation” in one another?

Hebrews 6:9–10

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“For God is not unjust; he will not forget your work and the love you have shown for his name.” Whose hidden service do you want to thank God for tonight? What does this verse say to someone who feels unnoticed?

Hebrews 6:10–12

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Our hope is “an anchor of the soul, sure and firm” – but it is cast upwards, behind the curtain, not down into the sea. What is your anchor fastened to when the storm comes, and what difference does it make that Jesus has gone there ahead of us?

Hebrews 6:13–20

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Abraham obtained the promise “after waiting patiently”. Name one promise of God you are waiting on, and each day this week bring it before him again with faith and patience.
- Encourage one person whose service usually goes unnoticed – tell them, in a note or in person, that God does not forget their work and their love.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 19–20 aloud together. Then pray in pairs for each other: name one storm or one long wait you are in, and thank God that his promise and his oath cannot fail. Close by thanking God for the faithful, hidden service of people in your church.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 7

A Priest for Ever

Hebrews 7:1–28

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever had to start again with a new doctor, teacher or adviser because the old one left? What was lost?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 6 Jesus entered behind the curtain as our forerunner, high priest for ever according to the order of Melchizedek. Now the author finally opens the subject he has been circling since 5:6–10. For Jewish believers it raised a fair question: how can Jesus be a priest if he came from the tribe of Judah and not from Levi? The author answers from the only two places in the Old Testament where Melchizedek appears: Genesis 14:18–20 and Psalm 110:4.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:1–2

[1] For this Melchizedek, king of Salem, priest of God Most High, met Abraham as he was returning from the defeat of the kings and blessed him, [2] and Abraham gave him a tenth of everything. His name means first "king of righteousness", and then he is also king of Salem, that is, "king of peace".

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:3–4

3 Without father, without mother, without genealogy, having neither beginning of
days nor end of life, but made like the Son of God, he remains a priest for all time.

4 See how great he is, to whom Abraham the patriarch gave a tenth of the best of the
spoils.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:5–7

5 Those of the sons of Levi who receive the priestly office have a commandment in
the law to collect a tenth from the people, that is, from their brothers and sisters,
though these too have come from Abraham's body. 6 But this man, who does not
trace his descent from them, collected a tenth from Abraham and blessed the one
who had the promises. 7 Beyond all dispute, the lesser is blessed by the better.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:8–10

[8] Here, mortal men receive tithes; there, one of whom it is testified that he lives.
[9] And one might even say that Levi himself, who receives tithes, paid a tenth
through Abraham, [10] for he was still in his ancestor's body when Melchizedek met
him.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:11–12

11 Now if perfection had come through the Levitical priesthood – for on the basis of it
the people received the law – what further need would there have been for another
priest to arise according to the order of Melchizedek, and not to be named
according to the order of Aaron? 12 For when the priesthood is changed, there is of
necessity a change of law as well.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:13–16

13 For the one of whom these things are said belonged to another tribe, from which
no one has ever served at the altar. 14 For it is clear that our Lord has arisen from
Judah, and in connection with that tribe Moses said nothing about priests.

15 And it is even more evident if another priest arises in the likeness of Melchizedek,
16 who has become a priest not according to a law of a fleshly commandment but
according to the power of an indestructible life.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:17–19

17 For it is testified:

You are a priest for ever
according to the order of Melchizedek.
18 For on the one hand, a former commandment is set aside because of its weakness
and uselessness 19 – for the law made nothing perfect – and on the other hand, a
better hope is brought in, through which we draw near to God.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:20–21

20 And it was not without a sworn oath. For the others became priests without a
sworn oath, 21 but he with a sworn oath, through the one who said to him:

The Lord has sworn
and will not change his mind:
You are a priest for ever.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:22–25

22 So much the more has Jesus become the guarantor of a better covenant.

23 The former priests were many in number, because they were prevented by death
from continuing in office; 24 but he, because he remains for ever, holds his
priesthood permanently. 25 That is why he is able to save completely those who
approach God through him, since he always lives to intercede for them.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:26–27

26 For it was fitting that we should have such a high priest: holy, innocent, undefiled,
separated from sinners, and become higher than the heavens. 27 He has no need,
like the high priests, to offer up sacrifices day after day, first for his own sins and
then for those of the people; for this he did once for all when he offered up himself.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 7:28–28

28 For the law appoints as high priests men who have weakness, but the word of the sworn oath, which came after the law, appoints a Son, made perfect for ever.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀγενεαλόγητος

agenealogētos · “without genealogy”

Genesis introduces almost every important figure with ancestors, birth and death – but not Melchizedek. He is not an angel or an appearance of Christ; the author reads the silence of Scripture: in the text Melchizedek is “made like the Son of God”, a portrait painted in advance of the Original (7:3).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἔγγυος

engyos · “guarantor”

Found only here in the New Testament (7:22). A mediator negotiates between two parties; a guarantor puts his own life, property and honour at stake that the terms will be kept – if we fail, the guarantor pays. Jesus was appointed with God's sworn oath, and so he guarantees a better covenant.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

εἰς τὸ παντελές

eis to panteles · "completely"

The phrase has a double shade: completely, to the deepest corner of our brokenness, and for all time, to the very end. He can save like this "since he always lives to intercede for them" (7:25).

THE BIG IDEA

Melchizedek, without genealogy and greater than Abraham, points to Jesus: a priest not by descent but by the power of an indestructible life and by God's oath, who always lives to intercede for us and who offered himself once for all.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Melchizedek is first “king of righteousness” and then “king of peace”. Why does the order matter? Where do we look for peace without letting righteousness touch the matter?

Hebrews 7:1–2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Genesis is silent about Melchizedek's parents, birth and death, and the author sees in that silence a portrait of the Son of God. How does it free us that Jesus' priesthood – and his blessing – do not depend on pedigree, background or a spiritual CV?

Hebrews 7:3

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“See how great he is.” Abraham gave a tenth of the best of the spoils – centuries before the law, out of gratitude. What would it mean for you to give Jesus the best part of your time and your heart rather than the leftovers?

Hebrews 7:4–10

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Verse 19 says “the law made nothing perfect”, but “a better hope is brought in, through which we draw near to God”. Where are you tempted to rely on a list of rules instead of drawing near?

Hebrews 7:11–19

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Jesus became a priest “according to the power of an indestructible life” and with a sworn oath. What does his resurrection – and God's oath – have to do with your confidence before God?

Hebrews 7:16–22

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The former priests were many “because they were prevented by death from continuing in office”, but Jesus “holds his priesthood permanently”. What does it mean for you that your high priest never retires and never has to be replaced?

Hebrews 7:23–24

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“He is able to save completely those who approach God through him, since he always lives to intercede for them.” Is there a part of your life you secretly think is beyond his reach? What does verse 25 say to it?

Hebrews 7:25–28

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week, remind yourself that Jesus is interceding for you today, and bring him one thing you fear you cannot manage.
- When old guilt comes back this week, remember that he did it “once for all when he offered up himself” – and refuse to add your own self-punishment to his sacrifice.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 24–25 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: thank Jesus that he is your guarantor and that he is praying for you now, and name before him one area you think is beyond his reach. Close with thanks for his once-for-all sacrifice (v. 27).

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 8

Shadow and Reality

Hebrews 8:1–13

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever seen an architect's model or a sketch of a house before it was built? How did the real building compare with it?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In chapter 7 the author showed that the person of our high priest, according to the order of Melchizedek, is far higher than the Levitical priests. Now chapter 8 turns to his ministry: a better sanctuary and a better covenant. For the first readers, cut off from the temple in Jerusalem and perhaps mocked for having no temple, no priest and no altar, this was a burning question. The author answers with the longest Old Testament quotation in the New Testament, Jeremiah 31:31–34, quoted as the Greek translation has it.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 8:1–3

[1] The main point of what we are saying is this: we have such a high priest, who took
his seat at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in the heavens, [2] a minister in
the sanctuary and in the true tent, which the Lord pitched, not a human being. [3] For
every high priest is appointed to offer gifts and sacrifices; so it is necessary for this
one too to have something to offer.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 8:4–5

4 Now if he were on earth, he would not even be a priest, since there are those who
offer the gifts according to the law. 5 They worship at a copy and shadow of the
heavenly things, just as Moses was instructed when he was about to complete the
tent: "See," he says, "that you make everything according to the pattern that was
shown you on the mountain."

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 8:6–8

6 But as it is, he has obtained a ministry that is as much superior as he is also
mediator of a better covenant, which has been enacted on better promises.

7 For if that first covenant had been faultless, no place would have been sought for a
second. 8 For he finds fault with them when he says:

See, days are coming, says the Lord,
when I will bring about a new covenant
with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 8:9–9

9 not like the covenant that I made with their fathers
on the day when I took hold of their hand
to lead them out of the land of Egypt;
for they did not remain in my covenant,
and I disregarded them, says the Lord.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 8:10–10

10 For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel
after those days, says the Lord:
I will put my laws into their minds,
and I will write them on their hearts;
and I will be their God,
and they shall be my people.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 8:11–12

11 And they shall not teach, each one his fellow citizen
and each one his brother, saying: Know the Lord,
for they shall all know me,
from the least of them to the greatest.
12 For I will be merciful toward their unrighteous deeds,
and I will remember their sins no more.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 8:13–13

13 By saying "new", he has made the first one old; and what is becoming old and growing aged is close to disappearing.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

κεφάλαιον

kephalaion · “the main point”

Not just a summary but the crowning point of the whole argument (8:1). And the core is a seated high priest: the earthly priests had to stand every day because their work was never finished (cf. 10:11); ours has taken his seat.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ὑπόδειγμα καὶ σκιά

hypodeigma kai skia · "copy and shadow"

A hypodeigma is a copy or sketch; Moses had to build according to the typos, the pattern or blueprint shown on the mountain (8:5). Like a shadow on the ground or an architect's scale model, the tent worship was good and God-given, but it pointed to a greater reality: Christ's ministry in heaven.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

διαθήκη καινή

diathēkē kainē · "a new covenant"

Kainos is often distinguished from neos: not only new in time but new in kind (the distinction is not strict – in 12:24 Hebrews also uses nea). Its promises are better because God no longer says "If you …" but "I will!" (8:8–12).

THE BIG IDEA

We have a high priest who has sat down in the true tent and is mediator of a better covenant, whose promises rest on God's own “I will”: he writes his laws on our hearts and remembers our sins no more.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

The main point is this: “we have such a high priest, who took his seat at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in the heavens”. Why would the author make a seated priest the core of his whole argument?

Hebrews 8:1–2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

The earthly priests serve “a copy and shadow of the heavenly things”. The first readers had lost the visible temple. Which visible things – forms, rituals, human approval – do we lean on for our spiritual security?

Hebrews 8:3–5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

If the first covenant had been faultless, there would have been no need for a second. Read verse 8: “For he finds fault with them when he says”. Where did the fault lie – and what did the old covenant not give?

Hebrews 8:6–9

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“I will put my laws into their minds, and I will write them on their hearts.” Do you experience God's will at the moment more like tablets of stone – an outward burden – or like something the Spirit is writing within you? What makes the difference?

Hebrews 8:10

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“For they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest.” Under the old covenant ordinary people depended on prophets, priests and kings. What does it mean for the youngest and the oldest in our group that each can know the Lord personally?

Hebrews 8:11

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Verse 12 begins with “For”: everything rests on it. “For I will be merciful toward their unrighteous deeds, and I will remember their sins no more.” The Greek uses a double negative – never, ever again. Is there a sin you have confessed long ago but still accuse yourself of? What would change if you believed this verse?

Hebrews 8:12

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“What is becoming old and growing aged is close to disappearing.” How can we honour the first covenant as God-given and still not go back to the shadows?

Hebrews 8:13

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week pray verse 10 for one specific area of your life where you are pushing yourself with clenched teeth: ask the Lord to write his will there on your heart and to change your desires from within.
- Write down one old, confessed sin that you keep digging up. Read verse 12 aloud over it, thank God that he will never again use it against you – and then tear up the paper.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 10–12 aloud together. Then pray in twos or threes: thank Jesus that he has sat down as our high priest in the true tent, ask him to write his laws on your hearts, and thank the Father, in your own words, for the promise of verse 12. Leave a moment of silence for each person to receive it personally.

EYES FIXED ON JESUS · SESSION 9

Through His Own Blood

Hebrews 9:1–28

TO GET STARTED

Think of a place you were not allowed into as a child – a staff room, a workshop, your parents' study. What did that closed door say to you?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 8 God declared the first covenant old. Now the author takes us on a reverent tour of the wilderness tent of Moses: two compartments, a heavy curtain, one high priest, once a year, never without blood. Then come two powerful words: “But Christ …”. Chapter 9 shows what his own blood achieves that no animal sacrifice could, why a death was necessary – the covenant also works like a will – and how Christ appears for us in the past, the present and the future.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:1–3

1 Now even the first covenant had regulations for worship and an earthly sanctuary.
2 For a tent was set up, the first one, in which were the lampstand and the table and
the loaves set out; this is called the Holy Place. 3 Behind the second curtain was a
tent called the Most Holy Place.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:4–6

4 It had a golden altar of incense and the ark of the covenant, covered on all sides
with gold, in which were a golden jar holding the manna, and Aaron's staff that had
budded, and the tablets of the covenant. 5 Above it were the cherubim of glory,
overshadowing the atonement cover. Of these things we cannot now speak in
detail.

6 With these things set up in this way, the priests go continually into the first tent to
carry out their acts of worship,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:7–9

7 but into the second only the high priest goes, once a year, and not without blood,
which he offers for himself and for the sins the people have committed in
ignorance. 8 By this the Holy Spirit makes clear that the way into the sanctuary has
not yet been revealed while the first tent still has standing. 9 This is a symbol for the
present time, according to which gifts and sacrifices are offered that cannot make
the worshipper perfect with respect to conscience,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:10–11

10 since they deal only with food and drink and various washings – regulations for
the flesh, imposed until the time of setting things right.

11 But when Christ came as high priest of the good things that have come, through
the greater and more perfect tent, not made with hands, that is, not of this creation,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:12–13

12 not through the blood of goats and calves but through his own blood, he entered
the sanctuary once for all and obtained eternal redemption. 13 For if the blood of
goats and bulls and the sprinkled ashes of a heifer make holy those who have been
defiled, so that their flesh is clean,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:14–15

14 how much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered himself without blemish to God, cleanse our conscience from dead works to worship the living God!

15 And for this reason he is mediator of a new covenant, so that, since a death has taken place for redemption from the transgressions committed under the first covenant, those who are called may receive the promise of the eternal inheritance.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:16–18

16 For where there is a will, the death of the one who made it must be established.
17 For a will takes effect only at death, since it is never in force while the one who made it is alive. 18 That is why not even the first covenant was inaugurated without blood.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:19–21

19 For when every commandment had been spoken by Moses to all the people
according to the law, he took the blood of the calves with water and scarlet wool and
hyssop, and sprinkled both the book itself and all the people, 20 saying: "This is the
blood of the covenant that God has commanded for you." 21 In the same way he
sprinkled with the blood the tent and all the vessels used in the ministry.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:22–24

22 Indeed, according to the law almost everything is cleansed with blood, and
without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness.

23 So it was necessary for the copies of the things in the heavens to be cleansed with
these, but the heavenly things themselves with better sacrifices than these. 24 For
Christ did not enter a sanctuary made with hands, a counterpart of the true one,
but into heaven itself, now to appear in the presence of God on our behalf.

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:25–27

25 Nor did he enter to offer himself again and again, as the high priest enters the
sanctuary year by year with blood that is not his own; 26 for then he would have had
to suffer again and again since the foundation of the world. But as it is, he has been
revealed once at the end of the ages to set aside sin by his sacrifice. 27 And just as it is
in store for human beings to die once, and after that comes judgment,

READ TOGETHER · HEBREWS 9:28–28

28 so Christ also, having been offered once to bear the sins of many, will appear a second time, apart from sin, to those who eagerly wait for him, for salvation.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

συνείδησις

syneidēsis · "conscience"

Literally knowing together with oneself: our inner moral awareness that we stand guilty before a holy God. Gifts and sacrifices could not make the worshipper perfect with respect to conscience (9:9); the blood of Christ will cleanse our conscience from dead works (9:14).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

λύτρωσις

lytrōsis · "redemption"

Buying the freedom of a slave or prisoner of war by paying a costly ransom. The Old Testament knew only a yearly atonement; Christ entered once for all (ephapax) and obtained eternal redemption, whose value never expires (9:12).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

διαθήκη

diathēkē · “covenant / will”

The same Greek word means both covenant and last will and testament. Our translation renders it “will” in 9:16–17 and “covenant” elsewhere, so that the change of meaning can be seen: a will takes effect only when the one who made it has died – and Christ leaves us the promise of the eternal inheritance (9:15).

THE BIG IDEA

The earthly tent showed that the way into God's presence was not yet open; Christ entered the sanctuary once for all through his own blood, cleanses our conscience from dead works so that we may worship the living God, appears now before God for us and will appear a second time for salvation.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Walk through the tent in verses 1–5. Inside the ark lay reminders of the people's grumbling, rebellion and broken law – and above it the atonement cover where the blood was sprinkled. What does that picture tell you about God?

Hebrews 9:1–5

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“But into the second only the high priest goes, once a year, and not without blood.” According to verse 8, what was the Holy Spirit teaching through this design? Does your relationship with God sometimes still feel like standing before a closed curtain?

Hebrews 9:6–8

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Gifts and sacrifices “cannot make the worshipper perfect with respect to conscience”; they cleanse only the outside. Which outward “washings” do we use today to quiet a guilty conscience – extra effort, good resolutions, days of self-reproach?

Hebrews 9:9–10

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“How much more will the blood of Christ … cleanse our conscience from dead works to worship the living God!” Notice the order: cleansed so that we may serve, not serving so that we may be cleansed. What changes when you live in that order?

Hebrews 9:11–14

DISCUSSION · 5/7

In verse 14 the whole Trinity is at work: the Son offered himself, through the eternal Spirit, to God. What does it mean to you that your salvation is the work of Father, Son and Spirit together?

Hebrews 9:14

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“For a will takes effect only at death.” And verse 22: “without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness”. Why did the Messiah have to die – could God not simply have declared us forgiven? What does it mean that no one can contest the inheritance Christ has left you?

Hebrews 9:15–22

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Verses 24–28 speak of three appearings: once at the end of the ages to set aside sin (past), “now to appear in the presence of God on our behalf” (present), and a second time, apart from sin, for salvation (future). Which of the three do you need most this week, and why?

Hebrews 9:23–28

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- When your conscience accuses you this week, don't do penance: name the sin before God, thank him for the blood of Christ (9:14) – and then do one act of service for someone, freely and gratefully.
- Begin each day this week by reminding yourself of verse 24: Christ is now in the presence of God on your behalf. Then bring your day to the Father with that confidence.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verse 14 aloud together. Pray in short sentences: thank God for one thing in the tent that points to Christ, confess quietly any dead works you rely on, and thank Jesus that he appears for us now. Close with verse 28: thank him that he will appear a second time for salvation.